

Singapore–Cambridge GCE O Level English Language (Syllabus 1184) Paper 2 — Comprehension Practice Paper 6

Time allowed: 1 hour 50 minutes

Total marks for Sections B and C: 45

Instructions to candidates

- Answer **all** questions in Sections B and C.
- The number of marks is given in brackets [] at the end of each question.
- Answer in **complete sentences** where instructed.
- For the summary in Section C, write **no more than 80 words**, not counting the words given to help you begin.

Section B — Text 3 (Narrative) [20 marks]

Text 3: After fifteen years working abroad, a daughter returns for the first time to the small village in rural Asia where she grew up.

1

The bus set me down at the foot of the lane just after noon, and for a long moment I did not move. Fifteen years had passed since I had last stood on that piece of red earth, and the country I had been carrying in my head all that time — kept warm in the dark, taken out occasionally and dusted — did not quite match the country in front of me. The lane was wider than I remembered. The mango tree that had once leaned over the gate was gone. A streetlight, painted a bright municipal blue, stood where the tree had been. I stood there with my suitcase, and felt, absurdly, like a guest who has arrived a day late at the wrong house.

2

My aunt was waiting at the door. She had written to say she would be, and she was. She had grown smaller. That was the first thing I noticed, and it shamed me to notice it. Her hair, which I remembered as a thick black plait, was now grey and pinned close to her head. Her hands, when she took mine, were dry and surprisingly cool, the way old paper is cool. She looked at me for a long time without speaking, and then she said, in our dialect, “You have eaten.” It was not a question. It was the form of welcome she had always used, and hearing it now, in that voice, in that doorway, was the first thing all morning that placed me back inside my own life.

3

She led me through the courtyard, talking quietly about nothing in particular, the way one talks to a child returning from a long illness. The old well had been filled in. There was a tiled square where it had stood, and a plastic water tank on a metal frame above. “Mains water came in 2014,” she said, when she saw me looking. “We do not need the well.” She said it without regret, the way a person reports the weather, but I felt the loss of that well in a way I could not, just then, explain to myself. As a child I had spent whole afternoons by it. I had dropped a tin cup down it once and watched my aunt fish the

cup out with a hook. I had thought, in my childish way, that the well would always be there. It was a stupid thing to have thought.

4

We ate lunch on the low table by the kitchen window. The food was the food of my childhood — rice, a thin yellow dal, a small pickle that bit the tongue — and yet my own mouth, accustomed for fifteen years to other tastes, met it as one meets an old friend across a noisy room: with recognition, with affection, and with a small awkwardness that neither party knows quite how to bridge. My aunt did not eat much. She watched me eat, instead, and refilled my plate with the patient authority of someone who had fed me for twenty years before. I remembered, with a sudden ache, that I had once found her authority irritating. I would have given a great deal, at that table, to be irritated by her again.

5

After the meal she rested, and I went out alone into the village. The lane, which I had walked every day of my childhood, was paved now. Two boys went by on a motorbike, faster than they should have, and did not glance at me. At the corner where the rice merchant had stood, there was a small mobile-phone shop with a glass front and a poster of a smiling young man holding a handset. I did not know the young man. I did not know the merchant's son, who, I would later learn, ran the shop. I walked past it slowly, the way one walks past a house one used to live in.

6

At the end of the lane, where the old tailor's shop had stood, the building was still there, though closed up and shuttered. The front window, however, had been cleaned only recently, and in it I caught sight of a woman I did not, for an instant, recognise. She was tall, and tired, and rather well dressed. Her hair was cut in a way no one in this village wore their hair. She was looking back at me with an expression of polite, careful interest. It took me a second longer than it should have to understand that the woman was myself. I stood there in the empty lane and looked at her, and she looked at me, and neither of us, just then, knew quite what to say.

7

I walked back slowly. My aunt was sitting by the door, watching the lane the way she had always watched the lane. She did not ask me where I had been. She made room on the bench beside her, and I sat down. Somewhere a cooking fire was being lit; the smell of woodsmoke crept along the wall. A dog barked once, far off, and stopped. I thought, sitting there, that I had come home, and I thought, in the same breath, that I had not — that home was not a place I could simply walk back into, the way one walks back into a room. It was something I would have to learn again, slowly, like a language I had once spoken well, and would now have to speak more carefully than before.

From Paragraph 1

1. The narrator says the country she had been carrying in her head was “kept warm in the dark, taken out occasionally and dusted.” Explain, in your own words, what this phrase tells us about her relationship with her home country while she was abroad. [2]

2. Give **two** details from Paragraph 1 that show the village has changed since the narrator last saw it. [2]

From Paragraph 2

3. The narrator says her aunt's hands were “dry and surprisingly cool, the way old paper is cool.” What does this comparison suggest about her aunt? [2]

4. The aunt's greeting, "You have eaten", is described as "not a question." Explain what this short, blunt remark suggests about how the aunt welcomes the narrator. [2]

From Paragraph 3

5. The narrator says of the old well, "It was a stupid thing to have thought."
(a) What had she thought, as a child, about the well? [1]
(b) Why does she now describe that childhood thought as "stupid"? [1]

From Paragraph 4

6. The narrator describes her mouth meeting the food "as one meets an old friend across a noisy room." Explain how the language in this paragraph conveys her **complicated feelings** about being home again. Support your answer with **two** details from Paragraph 4. [3]

From Paragraph 5

7. The narrator says she walked past the new phone shop "the way one walks past a house one used to live in." What does this comparison suggest about her feelings as she walked through the village? [2]

From Paragraph 6

8. The narrator does not, at first, recognise her own reflection. Give **one** detail from Paragraph 6 that explains why she did not recognise herself. [1]

9. Identify the **literary device** used in the sentence: "She was looking back at me with an expression of polite, careful interest." Explain its effect. [2]

From Paragraph 7

10. The narrator compares "home" to "a language I had once spoken well, and would now have to speak more carefully than before." Explain, in your own words, what this comparison suggests about her sense of belonging at the end of the passage. [2]

11. What is the **tone** of the final paragraph of the text? [1]

Section C — Text 4 (Non-narrative) [25 marks]

Text 4: A feature article on the rise of “ghost kitchens” and what they mean for the future of restaurants.

1

A few years ago, the words “ghost kitchen” would have suggested a haunted scullery in a Victorian novel. Today, they describe one of the fastest-growing forces in the global food industry. A ghost kitchen — also called a “cloud kitchen” or “dark kitchen” — is a commercial cooking space without a dining room, a waiter, or, in many cases, a sign on the street. It exists for one purpose only: to fulfil orders placed through food-delivery apps. By 2024, market analysts estimated the global ghost-kitchen industry at well over fifty billion US dollars, with the strongest growth recorded in cities such as Mumbai, Jakarta, São Paulo and Shanghai.

2

The model was made possible, almost overnight, by the smartphone. Once a critical mass of customers had grown used to ordering food on an app, the need for an actual restaurant — with its expensive frontage, its waiting staff, and its rent on a “good” street — began to look, to a certain kind of investor, like waste. Why pay for a fifty-seat dining room when only the kitchen produces revenue? The COVID-19 pandemic, which forced restaurants worldwide to close their doors for months on end, accelerated this question into urgency. Many establishments either pivoted to delivery-only operation or closed for good; many new “brands” launched, without ceremony, from industrial estates on the edge of town.

3

The advantages for the operator are real. Rent in an industrial park is a fraction of rent on a main street. Staff costs fall sharply, because no servers are required and the kitchen can be smaller. A single ghost-kitchen site can host several “brands” — a burger label, a noodle label, a salad label — all cooked by the same staff using the same equipment, and all marketed as separate restaurants on the apps. Menus can be tested and dropped in a week. A failed concept costs almost nothing; a successful one can be cloned to twenty cities in a year. For a young entrepreneur, the barrier to entry has rarely been lower.

4

For traditional restaurants, however, the picture is bleaker. A small family eatery on a busy street is now competing not only with the kitchen next door but with a dozen invisible kitchens listed above it on the app — kitchens that pay no front-of-house staff, no decor, and no rent on the same street. Worse, many of those listings are designed to look exactly like independent restaurants, complete with warm photographs and friendly names, when in reality they share a single industrial unit. Customers, scrolling through their phones at seven in the evening, rarely know the difference. Independent restaurateurs have long argued that this misleads diners and starves genuine neighbourhood restaurants of business. Several cities, including Paris and Toronto, have begun to consider rules requiring delivery apps to disclose when a “restaurant” is in fact a ghost-kitchen brand.

5

The effect on workers is also troubling. A traditional restaurant offers a range of jobs — server, host, bartender, manager, cook — many of which carry tips, public-facing skills, and a degree of social standing. A ghost kitchen offers only the kitchen role, and often at a faster pace, since the entire site is optimised for the speed of delivery. Riders, meanwhile, are squeezed at the other end of the chain: paid per delivery, given no fixed contract, and exposed to the weather, the traffic, and the algorithm. Several major studies, including a 2023 report by the International Labour Organization, have flagged the precariousness of food-delivery work as one of the defining labour issues of the decade.

6

There are quieter losses, too. A restaurant has, historically, been more than a place to eat. It has been

a place to court a partner, to celebrate a promotion, to wait out the rain, to argue with a brother. The street that lined three restaurants in a row was, almost without anyone planning it, a piece of public life. A street that lines three ghost kitchens, by contrast, is just a delivery loading bay. Town planners, having spent decades treating restaurants as engines of “high-street vitality”, have begun to ask, somewhat belatedly, what a city looks like when its eating happens largely behind closed doors.

7

None of this is to say that the ghost kitchen will, or should, disappear. For many young cooks, it is the only affordable way into the trade. For many busy households, a hot meal delivered on a wet Tuesday is a genuine kindness. But food, like reading and like music, is more than the object it produces. It is also the room it is eaten in, the people it is eaten with, and the neighbourhood that grows up around it. Whether the next decade preserves that wider meal — or quietly outsources it to an app — will depend, in the end, less on the technology than on the choices that customers, regulators, and cooks themselves are willing to make.

From Paragraph 1

12. In your own words, explain what a “ghost kitchen” is, according to Paragraph 1. [2]

From Paragraph 2

13. The writer says that, to “a certain kind of investor”, a dining room “began to look... like waste.” Explain, in your own words, why such an investor might see a dining room as wasteful. [2]

14. According to Paragraph 2, in what **two** ways did the COVID-19 pandemic accelerate the rise of ghost kitchens? [2]

From Paragraph 3

15. The writer says, “A failed concept costs almost nothing; a successful one can be cloned to twenty cities in a year.” Explain how this sentence makes the ghost-kitchen model sound **attractive to entrepreneurs**. [2]

From Paragraph 4

16. The writer puts the words “brands” and “restaurant” in inverted commas in Paragraphs 3 and 4. Explain what this **punctuation** suggests about his attitude to these terms. [2]

17. Why, according to Paragraph 4, have cities such as Paris and Toronto begun to consider new rules for delivery apps? Use your own words as far as possible. [2]

From Paragraph 5

18. The writer says that delivery riders are “squeezed at the other end of the chain.” Explain what this phrase suggests about the position of riders in the ghost-kitchen system. [2]

From Paragraph 6

19. The writer contrasts “a piece of public life” with “just a delivery loading bay.” Explain how this **contrast** makes the loss of traditional restaurants feel more serious. [2]

From Paragraph 7

20. The writer concedes that, for “many young cooks”, the ghost kitchen “is the only affordable way into the trade.” Why does he include this point, given his largely critical tone? [2]

21. What is the writer’s **tone** in the final sentence of the passage? [1]

22. Summary question [6 marks for content, 7 marks for use of own words and style]

Using your own words as far as possible, summarise **the advantages of ghost kitchens for the businesses that run them**, and **the concerns they raise for workers, traditional restaurants and food culture**, as outlined in the text.

Use **only** material from **Paragraphs 3 to 6** of Text 4.

Your summary must be in **continuous writing** (not note form). It must **not** be longer than **80 words** (not counting the words given to help you begin).

Begin your summary as follows:

For the businesses that run them, ghost kitchens offer ...

— END OF PAPER —